

REALITY IN FICTION

Game of thrones is one of the five novels so far in the series of novels called A Song of Ice and Fire. It is an epic high fantasy series which actions took place somewhere called Westeros. Houses of noble families are constantly in acts of peace and war seeking to transcend to the iron throne. As a student of International politics who has seen the series produced by HBO and read parts of the novels, I was stunned with the amount of power politics in the show and the novels. Liberal, realist, constructivist, neoconservative and more approaches to the political system in the seven kingdoms and beyond, different foreign policies and political actions and plots such as coups and alliances.

A massive of numbers of shows, books and movies have glimpses of reality within them that allow us to make them a window to understand certain things in life, but when it comes to GOT, it is much more than just a show but a complete framework to understand politics including the small issues of it (e.g. emancipation). This touch of reality in fiction can be helpful in explaining major issues in IR through narration. Clear examples of what can be explained through fiction can be psychological traits in Breaking Bad, alternative reading of the reality of Afghanistan under Taliban's rule in Hosseini's Kite Runner and finally the issues that follow emancipation through TV show- Game of Thrones.

House of Lannister - Realism

Classical Realism at its best.

The house showed a true realist spirit in dealing with enemies and friends. This house believed in power, transcending and yearning for it at the expense of anything and anyone. At the point of dynastic instability in Westeros that is similar to Italy in the fifteenth century, Lannisters gave up their moral standards for the sake of power. Cersei, an Offensive Realist within that house mentioned the importance of power in the political system against the moral standards saying “The Starks are honourable and admirable. The Lannisters are *survivors*. If they have to play a sneaky hand, they do, and they don’t see anything wrong with that.

Labelling the house as a realist does not mean everyone holds the same strategies, abilities to understand the world of politics or the same angles to perceive others. Lets examine three different characters from Game of Throne’s most realist house, The Lannisters.

1. King Joffrey – Machiavellian Realist:

“Fear is better than love.” King’s Joffrey’s brutality is derived from Machiavelli’s teachings over who is an ideal prince. The Italian advisor has an extensive version of Joffrey’s quote in his book The Prince:

“A controversy has arisen about this: whether it is better to be loved than feared, or vice versa. My view is that it is desirable to be both loved and feared; but it is difficult to achieve both and if one of them has to be lacking, it is much safer to be feared than loved.”

The idea of complete dictatorial and absolute rule with a will to do anything to pursue the power aspirations is what King Joffrey is doing. However, the kid was not raised learning politics, his mistakes caused him to be utterly hated, and eventually caused him his life. His cruelty, for a kid, can be seen as

the sudden change in role, from a kid to a king at the age being surrounded with realist advisors to the inclusion of his mother, Queen Cersei. A sudden change in role meant a change in perceptions and expectations as well as the extreme influence from the bureaucratic surrounding in the castle. Joffrey's regency was all about avoiding loss and achieving complete gains. David Welch explains the change in *Foreign Policy* with the expectations and perceptions of a leader:

"Foreign policy is most likely to change dramatically when leaders expect the status quo to generate continued painful losses. States will not alter their behaviour simply to try to realize some marginal gains. The clearest signals of an impending change are *desperation, stridency* and *distress*. The choice for change will often carry with it a risk of even greater loss – a risk of loss so great that, in many cases, no rational actor would accept it."

The kid king seemed to never change his attitude as he was becoming a second Mad King, his death separated him from this outcome that was likely to happen. His realism was not flawed but the kid himself was, his sadist and psychopathic behaviour caused him his life. Him, growing in that surrounding, facing the effect of the new surprising position and the influence of his surrounding made him in that position with all the flaws that cost him his life.

2. Tyrion Lannister – Lord Varys: Where power resides?

Replying to the statement preferring fear over love. Tyrion, The Imp, showed glances of wisdom advising the psychopath king Joffrey: "*Learn to use your ears more than your mouth or your reign will be shorter than I am.*" The Imp, and before him Lord Varys, are two of a few who really understand what power is, how strange, complex and hard to maintain it is and they know how useless owning power

could be. Holding defensive realism principles of reaching security rather than resorting to extreme measures at first chance was one of Tyrion's characteristics.

Knowing exactly where power is, who has it and who can use it made the Imp, Tyrion, trade carefully when it came to politics, wars and perceptions. One conversation with the Master of Spies Lord Varys, explained the whole idea of power and where it resides to Tyrion who eventually ended up being a political genius:

The eunuch rubbed his powdered hands together. "May I leave you with a bit of a riddle, Lord Tyrion?"

He did not wait for his answer. "In a room sit three great men, a king, a priest and a rich man with his gold. Between them stands a sell-sword, a little man of common birth and no great mind. Each of the great ones bids him slay the other two. "Do it," says the king, "for I am your lawful ruler." "Do it," says the priest, "For I command you in the names of the gods." "Do it," says the rich man," "and all this gold shall be yours." So tell me –who lives and who dies. And yet he is no one. He has neither crown not gold not favor of the gods, only a piece of pointed steel. That piece of steel is the power of life and death." ...

Varys said, swirling the wine in his cup. "Power is a curious thing, my lord Perchance you have considered the riddle I posed you that day in the inn?"

"It has crossed my mind a time or two," Tyrion admitted. "The king, the priest, the rich man-Who lives and who dies? Who will the swordsman obey? It's a riddle without an answer, or rather, too many answers. All depends on the man with the sword."

"And yet he is no one," Varys said. "He has neither crown nor gold nor favor of the gods, only a piece of pointed steel."

"That pointed piece of steel is the power of life and death."

“Just so ... yet if it is the swordsmen who rule us in truth, why we pretend our kings hold the power? Why should a strong man with a sword *ever* obey a child king like Joffrey, or a wine-sodden oaf like his farther?”

“Because these child kings and drunken oafs can call other strong men, with other swords.”

“Then these other swordsmen have the true power. Or do they? Whence came their swords? Why do *they* obey?” Varys Smiled. “Some say knowledge is power. Some tell us that all power comes from the gods. Others say it derives from law. Yet that day on the steps of Baelor's Sept, our godly High Septon and the lawful Queen Regent and your ever-so-knowledgeable servant were as powerless as any cobbler or cooper in the crowd. Who truly killed Eddard Stark, do you think? Joffrey, who gave the command? Ser Ilyn Payne, who swung the sword? Or ... another?”

Tyrion cocked his head sideways. “Did you mean to answer your damned riddle, or only to make my headache worse?”

Varys smiled. “Here, then. Power resides where men believe it resides. No more no less.”

“So power is a mummer's trick?” (Says Tyrion)

“A shadow on the wall,” Varys murmured, “yet shadows can kill. And ofttimes a very small man can cast a very large shadow.”

Where does it really reside? At first glance one would say with the sellsword, but who will direct that power towards the necks of the other two? The sword man represents people who share a common belief that power resides somewhere, either in the hands of the High Septon that derives from faith, the gold of the rich man or the honour and rule of law of the king. Each of the three own something powerful and the three try to influence the sell-sword the same way people are influenced on a daily basis, people who own power they really do not know. That power of influence occurs in real

life mostly in its repressive form, in media and religious authorities. Comparing governments to the small man, they can obviously take the role of the large shadow of power, delusional power.

Hobbes had similar notions of power and politics. The philosopher justifies the power given to monarch with the idea of *social contract* that offers it an absolute power against the will of people who present their freedom for the sovereign's protection. State of nature for Hobbes is anarchic and brutal, thus there is a need of a sovereign to control society. Hobbes makes a basis to realism with his pessimistic views on the nature of human beings being selfish and power lusting. Legitimacy, the notion by which actions of the rulers are justifiable within certain surrounding, is the justification of that reign in the case of king. The king did resort to law or legitimacy given to him by the social contract between his monarch and people.

Prior to the invasion of Iraq, George W. Bush used religion as a justification to his foreign policy actions. Many of his speeches included religious references to gain the popular, justify his actions and pursue his policy. One of these was his famous *With God on Our Side*. This religious imagery was not Bush's only but was, and is, a tool for everyone willing to influence and direct the course of power. Other examples include the narratives of Islamic Brotherhood in Egypt and Turkey. That use of biblical references and religious justifications is not, perhaps never, merely for religious or spiritual reasons. Cristina Odone's, in the aftermath of 9/11, highlighted Bush's religious references in his speech through her *Leave God out of it* article:

"Presumably the President's Prayer, unlike the Lord's, wastes no breath on forgiveness, but *urges the faithful* to bomb the hell out of those towel-heads, Amen! Coming in the wake of his talk about launching a 'crusade', the President's message was clear: God's on

our side. Beware the infidel – i.e, anyone who does not subscribe to our belief in America the beautiful.”

“To American ears, this kind of noise is as cosily familiar as Songs of Praise is to British ones. Since President Dwight D. Eisenhower spoke of the 'spiritual weapons' which 'forever will be our citizens' most powerful resource' at the beginning of the Cold War, successive governments have turned Americans' piety into their best defence shield system. Whatever the fight - the pinko commie enemy within, or the Evil Empire of the Soviet Union - the citizens of the world's No 1 superpower can rest easy in the knowledge that, when God's on your team, you've got nothing to fear.”

Money, as the third tool to influence the course of power according to Varys' riddle have been truly an influencing factor in distorting politics and their outcomes. Michael Bailey highlighted a two-ways influence of money in the world of politics: a legislative and an electoral strategy. The former deals with the fact of selling and buying votes and favours, the electoral one explains the course of showing certain image to public about a given candidate.

The riddle of the eunuch covered the course of power, how delusional it is using the shadow metaphor and how it just depends on the choice of the sell-sword –who might eventually revolt and kill the three. Each of the three used what can be called a *reinforcement* that has a reward for those who *hold certain ideas*. Alexander Wendt discussed the construction of power politics and highlighted this point as he pointed out this mechanism that follows the creation of common knowledge and *intersubjective meanings* and, of social structures that in their terms, interests and identities are identified. This common knowledge is formed through ideas and acts through interaction that could be aggressive or rewarding (detention, torture, money), religious and fanatic (with God on our side), emotional (axis of evil) or even legal. Power at this point is nothing but what people think of it, and who

people think it belong to, and that what was clearly illustrated in Varys – Tyrion conversation that made the two political geniuses pursue a special way of playing the political game rather than being played on.

3. Cersei – Realpolitik.

Cersei is another amazingly plotted character in GOT. Cersei, specifically in season one, showed her claws and being superbly protective due to the presence of the wise Ned Stark in Kings Landing.

In contrast to her brother who is fond of knowledge, she sees power in simple black or white. This misconception, lack of skill in dealing with internal political issues and pragmatism made her commit a large number of mistakes. One being that she ignored the national debt and decided to stop payments back to the Iron Bank of Bravos. Realpolitik seems the closest, if not the most accurate, to describe Cersei's political life and her view to the political game as a zero-sum game and that *"in the game of thrones, you win or you die."*

The realist view to their surroundings was not the only common element between Cersei's family and political scientists such as Morgenthau and Carr. Considering the political circumstances, the family pursues power at any expense and represent the model of humans being lustful to dominance, power and sin as well as being constantly fearful. That pattern of behaviour is predictable considering having an anarchic world and certainly push people to look at the *power of might over right*.

The problem with Cersei appeared after the death of Eddard Stark. Following that, the queen regent was stuck in a series of misconceptions and misjudgements as well as a lack of control over her son, the King. Her faith, which is strange for a realist like herself was one of these mistakes.

House of Starks – Idealism

Carr's archetypes of international politicians pictured liberals as the ones who seek to apply their grand principles regardless of the circumstances. Liberals of GOT were stiff living up to their moral standards and perhaps neglected the notions of power, same as Carr's British academics and individuals in the late 30's. Outcomes were not pleasant for that house throughout their life and struggle to pursue their endeavours similarly to the real world of politics, where liberal naivety and dreams of a cooperative world caused no progress and barely stagnated what needed to be fixed. Mearsheimer's article ***The False Promise of International Institutions*** tackled this liberal view to the world as well as certain points of what liberal institutionalists seek and what they actually achieve. Liberal institutionalism focuses on showing the rule of law and how it can trigger cooperation. Liberals though do not seek changing the behaviour of a state in order to face those who cheat and they do not seek or suggest a change in the anarchic nature of the whole system even after they recognize it but instead try to trigger certain short-term sacrifice for the sake of long-term cooperation. Mearsheimer's arguments continued to highlight the limits of Liberal institutionalism utility in the realm of security due to the constant fear of cheating. The latter is the main obstacle in reaching cooperation. Lannisters realist view concerning the fear, cheating and honour, friends and foes made them cautious, regardless of their skills in politics. Cersei's *"Everyone who isn't us is an enemy."* And *"When you play the game of thrones you win or you die. There is no middle ground"* sum up what is up with realism compared to the Wilsonianism of the Starks, most notably Eddard and his eldest, Robb. Many felt sorry for Ned getting murdered due to psychopathic urges of King Joffery. The man of honour had not had his head chopped at the behest of psychopathic Joffrey only but for his own naive beliefs that he may just trust people including Lord Baelish. The latter, being himself a defensive realist, warned Eddard Stark against trusting anyone including himself. That

warning was practically for some long term gains, but helping the Starks was no longer in Baelish's interest and he became instrumental in throwing Ned Stark to dungeons.

Through analysis, the liberalism of The Starks, Carr's argument against the utopians of the 30's could be applied to the great commitment of the Stark with ethics, moral standards and law. Carr's realism was more of an attack against hopeless idealism. Thinkers adopted a utopian view to the political world. That La Vie en Rose view made them, according to Carr, pay more attention to the possibilities of having a peaceful order rather than the real world and underestimating the power role in the political game. Wilsonianism is a good example to illustrate considering normative agenda of President Wilson and his hopes of binding the great powers with pieces of paper, thinking, similarly to the following idealists, that a utopian revolution will occur. Wilson, and most of the realists should be thankful not living in the fantasy world of Game of Thrones. Eddard Stark's paper that he used to claim his position in King's Landing was simply cut turning his hopes in the power of law into nothing. Game of thrones is clearly an example of Carr's realist view to the world having power as an *essential ingredient in politics* and not what idealists advocate such as cosmopolitan democracy and interdependence since law, at any point, can be ignored.

Ned Stark viewed the political system and its participants to be working under the power of oath, morality and law in a similar way to Wilson's thoughts of the League of Nations. What is missing, from both Stark's and Wilson's idealistic thoughts, is the nonexistence of a higher authority that they can actually refer or resort to. Liberals and idealists such as Eddard "Ned" Stark believed in such norms and pursued them regardless of the nature of the system: Anarchic. Both thought of exhausting every possibility of cooperation, being brutally honest and more of convincing others to submit to law before resorting to extreme measures. Committing these mistakes in the heart of a realist house cost Eddard Stark his head. At this point, if we are willing to criticize Eddard Stark for his mistakes and naivety, we would definitely bring back Carr's criticism of idealism and liberalism that are in contrast to realism,

ignore the concept of power in the political game, stick to one hopeless and utopian dream of an utterly cooperative world and ignore assessing the facts on the ground.

Mearsheimer's arguments has its applicability on more than just Eddard but extends to his son Robb, who trusted Walder Frey but eventually ended up getting murdered in the Red Wedding. Stannis Baratheon stuck to law, honour and Lord of Light to win against the Boltons. The latter started pre-emptive strikes and cost Baratheon his life. The bottom line is that this epic is beyond the good vs evil but exceeds to show the contending lenses that perceive the world and other entities of political system and the trust problem in international politics. For a first glance, realism seems to *clash* with basic values of those who try to observe it having it as that pessimistic theory. This pessimistic view does not seem to appear while watching the show or reading the books since the usual mind-set is having this good over evil in our heads. Americans view realism as hostile since it runs against their set of liberal values, the same way readers do not seem to like the Lannisters.

Beyond the good – evil debate, GOT geeks can clearly see the contradictions in the philosophical basis between realism and liberalism as well as other perspectives. Cersei and her family make an image of a Hobbesian picturing of human nature with their constant pursuance of power and their attempts to keep it with them. The Starks as well as Stannis kept forgetting about the cheating part and showed their naivety since day one. But beyond good and evil and distinguishing between realism and liberalism George R.R Martin contextualised and pictured *the enemy* in their human side, including slave-traders, executioners (The Hound and his constant fear of fire) and king slayers like Jaime Lannister, childhood and Brienne's love. Jaime, being a King Slayer, is a constant reminder to look back to the backgrounds of others to understand some patterns of their behaviour such as Saddam Hussein's troubled childhood. And even beyond, crucial components of the international system were pictured and their roles were emphasized through the scenes and chapters of GOT; Crusading liberal values (Daenerys against slavery), emancipation issues (jobless slaves), Globalization (sudden change in Essos' culture), non-state

actors (White Walkers), Confederations (Wildlings), different styles of leadership (Mance Rayder, the King beyond the Wall), gender and IR (Cersei – Daenerys) and more to be investigated through the window of Game of Thrones.